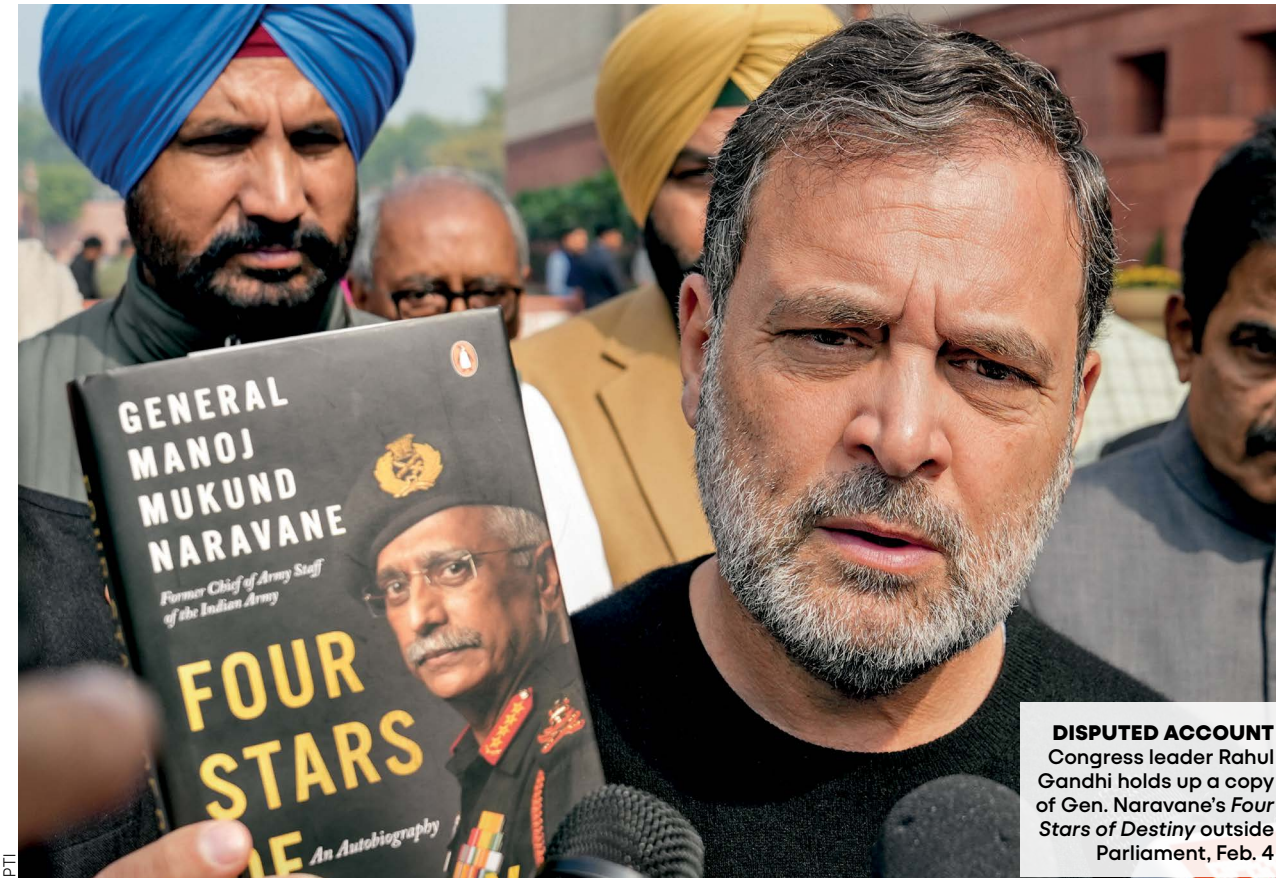
UPFRONT

ECOWATCH: SAVING THE DUGONGS *PG 9*

GRAPHIC: T20 STARS SHINE BRIGHT *PG 10*



PTI

DISPUTED ACCOUNT Congress leader Rahul Gandhi holds up a copy of Gen. Naravane's *Four Stars of Destiny* outside Parliament, Feb. 4

▶ CONTROVERSY

TEMPEST OVER A BOOK

Congress attempts to use Gen. M.M. Naravane's unpublished memoirs to call the government to account become a fireball that has singed Parliament

By KAUSHIK DEKA AND PRADIP R. SAGAR

IN INDIA, CONTROVERSIES OVER BOOKS USUALLY FOLLOW their publication. In the case of *Four Stars of Destiny*, the memoir of former army chief General M.M. Naravane, the storm arrived before the book itself. The controversy erupted on February 2, when Rahul Gandhi, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, attempted to read excerpts from it during the debate on the motion of thanks to the President's address. The passages reportedly suggested that during a particular point in India's standoff with China in Ladakh in August 2020, when Naravane asked defence minister Rajnath Singh and National Security Adviser Ajit Doval about the course of action over advancing Chinese tanks, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's conveyed message was: "*Jo uchit samjho, woh karo* (do what you think is right)." This directive, Gandhi argued, amounted to an abdication of political responsibility.

In answer, Rajnath Singh insisted that the book "has not been published" and Speaker Om Birla disallowed the